

THE OPPOSITION

BJP on its core competence—nationalism built around Hindu resurgence. So, his government has introduced patriotism in the school curriculum and organises free pilgrimage tours for Hindu senior citizens. In the run-up to the programme in Ayodhya, the Delhi government held a series of events, including a three-day Ram Leela, community kitchens and Sundar Kand recitals. Kejriwal was not invited to the Ram temple consecration, but even so hailed the event as a "matter of immense pride and happiness", and went on to say that AAP would adopt "10 principles of Ram rajya" in Delhi.

Meanwhile, in DMK-ruled Tamil Nadu, the BJP alleged an attempt by the state to stop the live streaming of the consecration ceremony which saw the Supreme Court intervene. The state replied in court that they had done no such thing and that the charges were "politically motivated", but there's no denying there were ripples. "While the impact of the Ram temple inauguration will favour the BJP in the north, other regions won't remain entirely aloof to the development. The BJP may consolidate its position in its stronghold and even increase its tally marginally in new frontiers such as the South Indian states and other areas such as Odisha and West Bengal," says Prof. Sanjay Kumar, co-director of Lokniti, Centre for the Study of Developing Societies (CSDS).



ANI

The scope of this expansion will also depend on the quality of the contest. Odisha CM and Biju Janata Dal (BJD) head Naveen Patnaik, who has kept both—the Congress-led INDIA and the BJP-led NDA (National Democratic Allaince)—at arm's length, has shown little anxiety over the BJP monopolising the Hindu docket nor sought to overplay the secular card. Having inaugurated a Rs 800 crore heritage corridor around Puri's renowned Jagannath temple just five days before the consecration in Ayodhya, the four-time CM has enough ammunition to battle the Hindutva messiahs.

One thing is for sure, though. No political party in India can stay away from religion any more. Prof. Narender Kumar of Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) says PM Modi's participation in the Ayodhya event marks a signal moment in the departure of secularism as envisioned in the Constitution from Indian politics. The message is loud and clear. "The construction of the Ram temple has made millions happy in the country. So, it's a positive development. Most politicians know that by associating with this, they only stand to gain," says psephologist Pradeep Gupta of Axis My India.

However, he doesn't believe the Ram temple will be a decider in 2024. "People will choose between the *daava* (claims) of the government in terms of performance and the *vaada* (promises) of the challengers," says Gupta. Academic-turned-political activist Yogendra Yadav says the Opposition must focus on the economy, governance and national security, three areas where the performance of the BJP government has been a "disaster". "Unemployment is the biggest issue. Come out with a new policy. It has to be Modi vs *mudda* (issue)," says Yadav.

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By staying away from the inauguration, the Congress may have sought to prove its secular credentials, but also lost the goodwill of a large section of the voters. It has not been long since Rahul proclaimed himself a "*janeudhari* Brahmin" and "Shiv bhakt". "The trouble is that Congress is also guilty of using religion for electoral gains," says Yadav. In fact, the party itself credits the late prime minister Rajiv Gandhi for unlocking the Babri Masjid gates in 1986 to allow Hindus to pray within the mosque's premises. Historian Ramachandra Guha says the Faizabad district judge's order allowing it "was widely believed to have been directed from Delhi, from the prime minister's office". Three years later, the Congress government also allowed the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) to perform shilanyas at the disputed site. That Rajiv launched the party's election campaign for the 1989 Lok Sabha election from Ayodhya-Faizabad also indicates that the Congress sought to feed off the electoral advantages from the Ram temple controversy.

Over three decades later, beaten and bruised by BJP's Hindutva politics in two successive polls, the Congress has